



MODULE 01

The Bond

Bonded Foundations



Contents

01	A Dog Is...	4
02	Building Trust	9
03	A Secret Language	14
04	The Skills Map	19
05	The 3 D's	24

Welcome

This is where it all begins – not with tricks, not with routines, but with something deeper. Something that will shape everything you and your dog do together from this point forward.

This module is about the bond.

Before we teach a single skill, we need to build a relationship that makes learning possible. A relationship built on trust, clarity, and genuine connection.

In the lessons ahead, you will learn what a dog truly is, how to earn their trust, how to communicate in a way they understand, and how to map the skills you will both need to grow together.

Take your time. Read slowly. Reflect honestly. And remember – the bond you build here is the foundation for everything that comes next.

With love,

Roni



LESSON 01

A Dog Is...

Exploring what a dog truly is – instincts, senses, and natural behaviors – and learning to work with them, not against them.

LESSON 01

A Dog Is...

Before we teach a single trick, before we shape a single behavior, we need to understand who we are working with.

A dog is not a small human. A dog is not a robot. A dog is a living, breathing, feeling being with instincts, emotions, and a view of the world that is completely different from ours.

Dogs experience the world nose-first. Their sense of smell is tens of thousands of times stronger than ours. They read body language faster than we can speak. They feel tension in a leash, joy in a voice, and uncertainty in hesitation.

When we understand this, everything changes.

We stop expecting them to “just know” what we want. We stop punishing confusion. We start communicating in a way they can actually understand.

Working With Instincts

Every behavior your dog shows has a reason behind it. Sniffing is not disobedience – it is how they gather information. Chewing is not destruction – it is a natural need. Pulling on the leash is not defiance – it is excitement and curiosity.

When we label these behaviors as “bad,” we miss the point entirely. These are not problems to fix. They are instincts to understand and redirect.

A dog who sniffs can learn to use that nose on cue. A dog who chews can be given appropriate outlets. A dog who pulls can learn that walking beside you is more rewarding.

Your Responsibility

As handlers, we carry the greater responsibility in this partnership. We are the ones who chose to bring a dog into our lives. We are the ones who set the rules, the environment, and the expectations.

That means it is our job to:

- Learn how dogs think and feel
- Provide clear, consistent communication
- Create an environment where success is possible
- Be patient when learning takes time
- Celebrate progress, no matter how small

Training is not something we do to our dogs. It is something we do with them. It is a conversation, not a command.



Trust, Engagement, and Clarity

These are not tricks. They are not commands. They are daily skills that make everything else possible.

Trust means your dog believes that being near you is safe and good. Engagement means your dog wants to be part of what you are doing. Clarity means your dog understands what you are asking.

Without these three things, no trick will hold. No routine will flow. No performance will feel real.

With them, everything becomes possible.



Training is not something we do to our dogs. It is something we do with them. It is a conversation, not a command.

– Lesson 1: A Dog Is...

LESSON 02

Building Trust

Defining trust as a two-way relationship and learning to set your dog up for success through clarity and safety.



LESSON 02

Building Trust

Trust is not a trick you teach. It is not a cue you give. Trust is a feeling – and it goes both ways.

Your dog needs to trust that you will keep them safe, that your feedback is fair, and that being near you is a good place to be.

And you need to trust your dog – trust that they are trying, trust that confusion is not defiance, and trust that progress takes time.

Trust is built in small moments. Every time you set your dog up for success instead of failure, trust grows. Every time you respond to a mistake with patience instead of frustration, trust deepens.

It is the foundation of everything we will build together.

Three Questions to Guide You

Every time you train, every time you interact with your dog, ask yourself these three questions. They will keep you honest, keep you kind, and keep your dog safe.

1. Am I setting my dog up for success?

This means thinking ahead. Is the environment too distracting? Is the task too hard? Have I broken this down into small enough steps?

If your dog is failing repeatedly, the problem is not your dog. The problem is the setup.

2. Am I being clear?

Dogs do not speak our language. They rely on our consistency, our timing, and our body language to understand what we want. If your dog seems confused, ask yourself: have I been clear enough?

3. Is my dog enjoying this?

Training should not be a chore – not for you, and not for your dog. If your dog is shutting down, looking away, or trying to leave, something needs to change.

Joy is not a luxury in training. It is a requirement.

Making Feedback Safe

Your dog needs to know that trying is always safe. That making a mistake will not lead to punishment or frustration.

When feedback is safe, dogs become braver. They offer more behaviors. They experiment. They engage.

When feedback feels dangerous, dogs shut down. They stop trying. They become careful instead of creative.



Celebrating Small Wins

One of the most powerful things you can do as a trainer is to genuinely celebrate your dog's effort.

Not just the big moments – the perfect trick, the flawless routine. But the small ones too. The moment your dog looks at you instead of the distraction. The moment they hold a position for one extra second. The moment they try something new.

Your appreciation needs to be real. Dogs know the difference between genuine joy and mechanical praise. When you celebrate with your whole heart, your dog feels it. And that feeling builds trust faster than any treat ever could.

Can your dog trust you?

KEY IDEA

The Three Questions

Before every training session, ask yourself:

1. Am I setting my dog up for success?
2. Am I being clear?
3. Is my dog enjoying this?

If the answer to any of these is no, adjust before continuing.

03

LESSON 03

A Secret Language

Building a shared communication system through markers,
tone, and consistency.

A Secret Language

Imagine trying to learn something new in a language you do not speak. No one explains the rules. No one tells you when you are right or wrong. You are just expected to figure it out.

That is what training feels like for a dog without a clear communication system.

In this lesson, we are going to build a shared language – a set of signals that mean the same thing every single time. These signals are called markers, and they are the foundation of everything we will teach from this point forward.

Markers are not commands. They are information. They tell your dog: you got it right, keep going, take a break, or try again.

When your dog understands these signals, confusion disappears. Confidence grows. And learning becomes a joy for both of you.

The Four Essential Markers

“YES” – Confirmation

This is the most powerful word in your training vocabulary. It means: that exact thing you just did is correct, and a reward is coming.

Say it with energy. Say it with joy. Make it unmistakable.

The moment you say “YES,” stop everything and reward. The timing matters. The reward must follow immediately so your dog connects the behavior to the outcome.

“TOV” – Keep Going

This marker means: you are on the right track, keep doing what you are doing.

Use it during duration behaviors – when your dog is holding a position, maintaining focus, or working through a sequence. It is encouragement without interruption.

“OK” – Release

This marker means: you are free. The exercise is over. You can relax, move, sniff, or play.

Every exercise needs a clear ending. Without a release marker, your dog is left guessing: am I still working? Can I move? What is happening?

The release gives your dog permission to decompress. It is a gift of clarity.

“HALO” – Mistake Signal

This is perhaps the most delicate marker. It means: that was not quite right, but it is okay. Let us try again.

The tone matters enormously here. “HALO” should sound gentle, neutral, and encouraging. Never sharp. Never frustrated. It is information, not punishment.

When used correctly, “HALO” turns mistakes into learning moments.



Consistency Is Everything

Your markers only work if they mean the same thing every time. To every person in your household. In every environment. In every emotional state.

Ask yourself:

- Does everyone in the family use the same words?
- Do we all use the same tone?
- Are we consistent even when we are tired or frustrated?

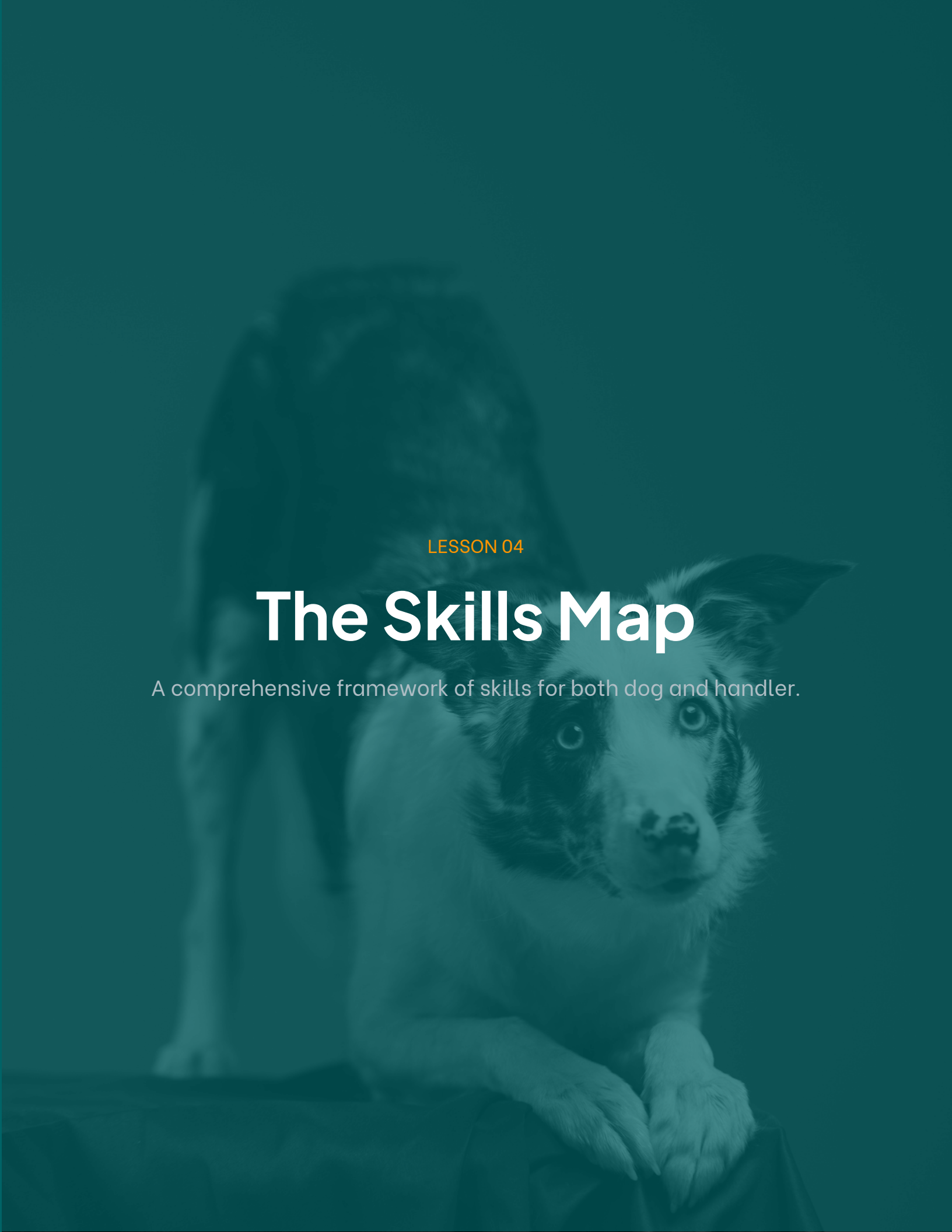
If the answer is no, your dog is receiving mixed signals. And mixed signals create confusion, not confidence.

Consistency is not about being perfect. It is about being intentional.



*When your dog understands these signals,
confusion disappears. Confidence grows.
And learning becomes a joy for both of you.*

– Lesson 3: A Secret Language

A dog, possibly a Border Collie, is the central focus of the image. It is sitting and looking directly at the camera with a calm expression. Its front paws are resting on a dark, textured surface in the foreground. The dog has white fur with dark patches around its eyes and on its ears. The background is a solid, dark teal color.

LESSON 04

The Skills Map

A comprehensive framework of skills for both dog and handler.

LESSON 04

The Skills Map

Before we can dance, we need to walk. Before we can perform, we need to prepare. And before we can build routines, we need to build skills.

This lesson is your map. It shows you every skill that matters – for your dog and for you – so you know exactly where to focus your energy.

Think of these skills as the building blocks of everything we will create together. Some are psychological. Some are physical. All of them are essential.

You do not need to master everything at once. In fact, trying to do so will only lead to frustration. Instead, use this map to understand the full picture, and then choose where to begin.

Every great team is built one skill at a time.

Skills for Your Dog

Psychological Skills

- **Confidence** – The willingness to try new things without fear of failure.
- **Focus** – The ability to maintain attention on you despite distractions.
- **Sequencing** – Understanding that behaviors can be chained together in order.
- **Duration** – The ability to maintain a behavior over time.
- **Resilience** – The ability to recover from mistakes and keep trying.
- **Playing With Toy** – Controlling the emotions while in prey drive.

Physical Skills

- **Taking Treats** – Accepting rewards gently and calmly from your hand.
- **Following the Handler** – Moving with you naturally and attentively.
- **Luring** – Following a treat or hand target into position.
- **Directional Movement** – Moving forward, backward, sideways, and in circles with control.
- **Platform Work** – Confidence and precision on elevated or small surfaces.
- **Pivoting** – Rotating the body around a fixed point with control.
- **Balance** – Stability on different surfaces and in different positions.
- **Body Awareness** – Understanding where each part of the body is in space.
- **Transitions** – Moving smoothly between different positions and behaviors.
- **Playing With Toy** – Understanding the stages of prey and how to move the body for each of the stages.

Skills for You

Psychological Skills

- **Empathy** – Understanding what your dog is feeling and responding with care.
- **Patience** – Allowing learning to happen at the right pace without rushing.
- **Planning** – Structuring sessions with clear goals and realistic steps.
- **Confidence** – Trusting yourself and your training decisions.
- **Spatial Awareness** – Understanding where you and your dog are in relation to each other.
- **Knowing Your Dog** – Reading your dog's signals, moods, and limits accurately.
- **Listening to Music** – Feeling rhythm, tempo, and phrasing to guide choreography.
- **Multitasking** – Managing cues, movement, and timing simultaneously.

Physical Skills

- **Voice and Tone Control** – Using your voice clearly, consistently, and with the right energy.
- **Wrist Work** – Precise hand and wrist movements for luring and signaling.
- **Footwork** – Moving your feet with intention, rhythm, and spatial awareness.
- **Timing** – Delivering markers, rewards, and cues at exactly the right moment.
- **Physical Stamina** – The endurance to train, perform, and stay present through long sessions.
- **Playing With Toy** – Understanding how to move in a “prey” way and how to play in a way that makes your dog more interested in the joint play.

SUMMARY

The Skills Map

Every skill you and your dog need, mapped across four categories.

Dog Psychological

- Confidence
- Focus & Engagement
- Sequencing
- Duration
- Emotional Resilience
- Playing With Toy

Dog Physical

- Taking Treats
- Following the Handler
- Luring
- Directional Movement
- Platform Work
- Pivoting
- Balance & Flexibility
- Body Awareness
- Transitions
- Playing With Toy

Human Psychological

- Empathy
- Patience
- Planning
- Confidence
- Spatial Awareness
- Knowing Your Dog
- Listening to Music
- Multitasking

Human Physical

- Voice & Tone Control
- Wrist Work
- Footwork
- Timing
- Physical Stamina
- Playing With Toy



LESSON 05

The 3 D's

Understanding Duration, Distance, and Distractions as the three variables that shape training difficulty.

The 3 D's

Every behavior your dog learns exists within a context. And that context is shaped by three variables that we call the 3 D's: Duration, Distance, and Distractions.

Understanding these three factors is one of the most important things you can do as a trainer. They explain why your dog can perform perfectly at home but struggles at the park. Why a behavior that lasted ten seconds yesterday falls apart after three seconds today.

The 3 D's are not obstacles. They are tools. When you learn to manage them, you can set your dog up for success in any situation.

The key principle is simple: if one D increases, another should decrease. This keeps the challenge manageable and your dog confident.

The Three Variables

Duration

How long your dog maintains a behavior. This could be holding a sit, maintaining eye contact, or staying in position during a routine.

Duration is built gradually. Start with one second. Then two. Then five. Never jump ahead faster than your dog can handle.

If your dog breaks the behavior, you have pushed too far. Go back to a duration they can succeed at and build again.

Distance

The physical space between you and your dog, or between your dog and a distraction. Distance changes everything.

A dog who can sit perfectly beside you may struggle when you step three feet away. A dog who ignores a treat on the floor may lose focus when the treat is right in front of their nose.

Distance is a variable you control. Use it wisely.

Distractions

Everything in the environment that competes for your dog's attention. Other dogs, sounds, smells, people, movement.

Distractions are the hardest variable to manage because you cannot always control them. But you can control your response to them.

Start training in low-distraction environments. Build success there first. Then gradually introduce more challenge.



Balancing the Variables

The golden rule of the 3 D's is this: if one goes up, another should come down.

If you are increasing duration, reduce distractions. If you are adding distance, shorten the duration. If the environment is full of distractions, stay close and keep it brief.

This is not about lowering your expectations. It is about being strategic. You are building your dog's confidence and capability one layer at a time.

When your dog succeeds, they want to try again. When they fail repeatedly, they shut down. Your job is to keep them in the success zone.

KEY IDEA

The Golden Rule

If one D increases, another should decrease.

Duration. Distance. Distractions.

Manage these three variables to keep your dog in the
success zone.

Thank You

You have completed Module 1: The Bond.
The foundation is set. The journey continues.



www.bonded.dog